

g2(0) cases

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abstract

We consider a negatively charged quantum dot (QD) with a resident electron embedded in a symmetric optical microcavity. The optically active transition couples the ground state, in which the QD hosts a single resident electron, to the negatively charged trion X^- with energy E_t , built of an electron singlet and a heavy hole. The energy of the fundamental cavity mode $\hbar\omega_0$ coincides with that of the trion transition, $E_t = \hbar\omega_0$, and the interaction with all other modes is neglected. The system is driven by a laser pulse of carrier frequency ω_L , detuned from the transition by $\Delta = \omega_L - \omega_0$, and is subject to a magnetic field B_x , perpendicular to the growth axis. We are interested in the non-resonant regime, in which the detuning exceeds both the spectral width Γ_L of the pump pulse and the width Γ of the cavity mode, $\omega_L - \omega_0 \gtrsim \Gamma_L, \Gamma$, as sketched in Fig. 1. As the pump pulse carries a large number of photons, this separation of scales allows to describe it as a classical field with the Rabi frequency $\Omega_R(t)$, whereas the cavity mode, which is not directly fed by the laser, contains only a few photons and therefore has to be retained at the operator level.

Within the rotating wave approximation the Hamiltonian of the system, which accounts for the coupling to the cavity mode, for the interaction with the driving laser field and for the interaction with the magnetic field, reads (hereafter $\hbar = 1$)

$$\begin{aligned} \hat{H} = & E_t \sum_{\sigma=\uparrow,\downarrow} \hat{d}_\sigma^\dagger \hat{d}_\sigma + \omega_0 \sum_{\lambda=\pm} \hat{b}_\lambda^\dagger \hat{b}_\lambda \\ & + g \left(\hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger \hat{a}_\uparrow \hat{b}_+ + \hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \hat{a}_\downarrow \hat{b}_- \right) + g^* \left(\hat{a}_\uparrow \hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger \hat{b}_+^\dagger + \hat{a}_\downarrow \hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \hat{b}_-^\dagger \right) \\ & + \Omega_R(t) \sum_{\sigma=\uparrow,\downarrow} \left(e^{-i\omega_L t} \hat{d}_\sigma^\dagger \hat{a}_\sigma + e^{i\omega_L t} \hat{d}_\sigma \hat{a}_\sigma^\dagger \right) \\ & + \mu_B g_e B_x \left(\hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \hat{a}_\uparrow + \hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger \hat{a}_\downarrow \right) + \mu_B g_t B_x \left(\hat{d}_\downarrow^\dagger \hat{d}_\uparrow + \hat{d}_\uparrow^\dagger \hat{d}_\downarrow \right) \end{aligned} \quad (1)$$

where the last two terms describe the Zeeman interaction in the transverse field. Here $\hat{a}_\sigma^\dagger$ is the creation operator of the resident electron, where $\sigma = \uparrow, \downarrow$ denotes the spin state $|\pm 1/2\rangle$; $\hat{d}_\sigma^\dagger$ is the creation operator of the negatively charged trion, where σ denotes the heavy hole spin state $|\pm 3/2\rangle$; $\hat{b}_\pm^\dagger = (\hat{b}_H^\dagger \pm i\hat{b}_V^\dagger)/\sqrt{2}$ is the creation operator of a cavity photon with circular polarization $\sigma_\pm$, expressed through the linearly polarized modes H and V ; g is the effective QD–cavity coupling parameter; μ_B is the Bohr

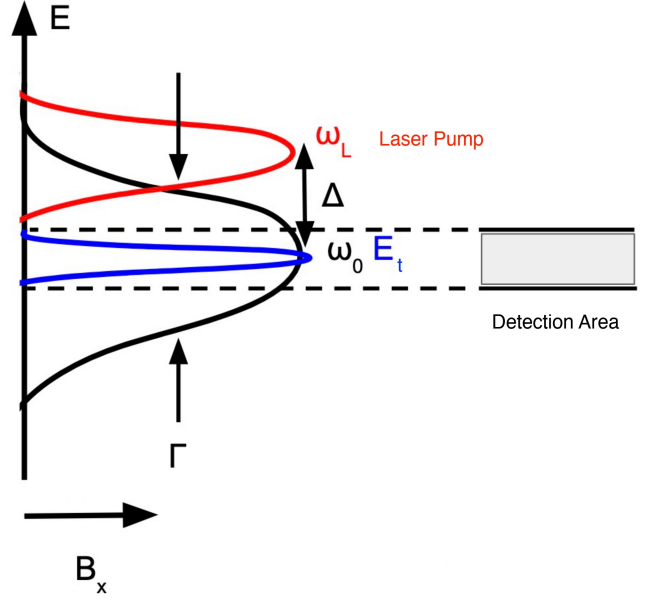


FIG. 1. Energy scheme of the system. The cavity mode of width Γ (black) is centered at ω_0 and is resonant with the trion transition E_t (blue). The pump pulse (red) has the carrier frequency ω_L and the spectral width Γ_L , and is detuned from the mode by Δ . The shaded box marks the spectral window of detection. The magnetic field B_x is applied perpendicular to the growth axis.

magneton, g_e and g_t are the in-plane g -factors of the resident electron and of the trion, respectively.

The optical selection rules fix the spin structure of the light–matter coupling: a σ_+ photon converts a resident electron $|+1/2\rangle$ into the trion with the heavy hole $|+3/2\rangle$, and a σ_- photon converts $|-1/2\rangle$ into $|-3/2\rangle$. Consequently, only the triads $(\hat{a}_\uparrow, \hat{d}_\uparrow, \hat{b}_+)$ and $(\hat{a}_\downarrow, \hat{d}_\downarrow, \hat{b}_-)$ are coupled, and the polarization of the emitted photon is rigidly tied to the spin state of the QD. The transverse field B_x , in turn, mixes the two spin branches, which is the mechanism that correlates the polarizations of the two emitted photons.

To describe the evolution of the system coupled to its environment, the Hamiltonian dynamics has to be supplemented by the dissipative terms of the Lindblad equation

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$$\partial_t \hat{\rho} = -i [\hat{H}, \hat{\rho}] + \sum_i \gamma_i \left(\hat{V}_i \hat{\rho} \hat{V}_i^\dagger - \frac{1}{2} \{ \hat{V}_i^\dagger \hat{V}_i, \hat{\rho} \} \right) \equiv \hat{\mathcal{L}} \hat{\rho} \quad (2)$$

where $\{\cdot, \cdot\}$ is the anticommutator, and γ_i and $\hat{V}_i$ are the rate and the jump operator of the i -th channel. Three dissipation channels are retained.

The first one is the escape of photons from the cavity mode into the environment, which is the process that delivers the photons to the detector. Its jump operator and rate are

$$\hat{V}_{\text{phot}} = \hat{b}_\pm, \quad \gamma_{\text{phot}} = \Gamma \quad (3)$$

where Γ is the width of the cavity mode.

The second channel is the pure dephasing of the optical transition induced by acoustic phonons, which is responsible for the damping of the Rabi oscillations. The corresponding jump operator is

$$\hat{V}_{\text{phon}} = \sum_{\sigma=\uparrow, \downarrow} \left(\hat{a}_\sigma^\dagger \hat{a}_\sigma - \hat{d}_\sigma^\dagger \hat{d}_\sigma \right), \quad \gamma_{\text{phon}} = \alpha \Omega_R^2 \quad (4)$$

The third channel is the dephasing of the resident electron spin. It is described by the operator

$$\hat{V}_{\text{spin } i} = \begin{pmatrix} \hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger & \hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \\ \hat{a}_\uparrow & \hat{a}_\downarrow \end{pmatrix} \hat{\sigma}_i \begin{pmatrix} \hat{a}_\uparrow \\ \hat{a}_\downarrow \end{pmatrix} + \begin{pmatrix} \hat{d}_\uparrow^\dagger & \hat{d}_\downarrow^\dagger \\ \hat{d}_\uparrow & \hat{d}_\downarrow \end{pmatrix} \hat{\sigma}_i \begin{pmatrix} \hat{d}_\uparrow \\ \hat{d}_\downarrow \end{pmatrix} \quad (5)$$

where $\hat{\sigma}_i$ with $i = x, y, z$ are the Pauli matrices acting in the spin space of the resident electron and of the trion. Since the magnetic field is directed along x , the operators $\hat{V}_{\text{spin } y}$ and $\hat{V}_{\text{spin } z}$ relax the transverse spin component, whereas $\hat{V}_{\text{spin } x}$ adds a pure dephasing of the longitudinal ones. The three rates are therefore expressed through the longitudinal and transverse spin relaxation times T_1 and T_2 as

$$\gamma_{\text{spin } x} = \frac{1}{T_1}, \quad \gamma_{\text{spin } y} = \gamma_{\text{spin } z} = \frac{1}{T_2} \quad (6)$$

This channel destroys the coherence between the two spin branches and therefore directly degrades the polarization entanglement of the emitted photon pair.

Equation (2) is solved with the initial condition set by the state of the system before the arrival of the pump pulse, when the cavity mode is empty and the QD hosts only the resident electron. In the transverse magnetic field the eigenstates of the electron spin are the symmetric and antisymmetric superpositions $(|\uparrow\rangle \pm |\downarrow\rangle)/\sqrt{2}$ split by the energy $2\mu_B g_e B_x$, and their populations follow the Boltzmann distribution at the lattice temperature T . The initial density matrix therefore reads

$$\hat{\rho}_0 = \frac{f(B_x)}{2} \left(\hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger + \hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \right) |0\rangle \langle 0| (\hat{a}_\uparrow + \hat{a}_\downarrow) + \frac{f(-B_x)}{2} \left(\hat{a}_\uparrow^\dagger - \hat{a}_\downarrow^\dagger \right) |0\rangle \langle 0| (\hat{a}_\uparrow - \hat{a}_\downarrow) \quad (7)$$

where $f(B_x) = e^{\mu_B g_e B_x / T} / (e^{\mu_B g_e B_x / T} + e^{-\mu_B g_e B_x / T})$ and the temperature is measured in energy units.

The quantities measured in the experiment are the polarizations of the photons that reach the detector, so the observables have to be extracted from the projections of the full density matrix onto the sectors with a given number of emitted photons. Two routes bring a photon to the detector. It can leave the cavity already during the pulse, which corresponds to a quantum jump $\hat{b}_\lambda$ at a time $t_1 < \tau$, or it can be emitted after the end of the pulse by a trion that has survived until $t = \tau$ and then recombines with a probability close to unity. In the latter case the polarization of the photon is fixed by the trion spin through the selection rules, so that the spin index σ of an unrecaptured trion can be read as the polarization index of the photon it is going to emit.

It is therefore convenient to introduce, along with the solution $\hat{\rho}(t)$ of Eq. (2) with the initial condition (7), the conditional density matrix $\hat{\rho}^{(\lambda)}(t|t_1)$. The latter is the solution of the same equation propagated from t_1 to t with the initial condition $\hat{b}_\lambda \hat{\rho}(t_1) \hat{b}_\lambda^\dagger$, that is, the state of the system given that a photon of circular polarization λ has escaped from the mode at the instant t_1 .

The one-photon density matrix is then a 2×2 matrix in the basis of the circular polarizations $\lambda = \pm$,

$$(\hat{\rho}_1)_{\lambda\lambda'} = \langle 0 | \hat{d}_\lambda \hat{\rho}(\tau) \hat{d}_{\lambda'}^\dagger | 0 \rangle + \delta_{\lambda\lambda'} \Gamma \int_0^\tau dt_1 \sum_{\sigma=\uparrow, \downarrow} \langle 0 | \hat{a}_\sigma \hat{\rho}^{(\lambda)}(\tau|t_1) \hat{a}_\sigma^\dagger | 0 \rangle \quad (8)$$

The first term collects the events in which the QD is left in the trion state at the end of the pulse and no photon has escaped before, while the second one collects the events in which a single photon has already been emitted during the pulse and the QD has returned to the ground state.

The two-photon sector is spanned by the states $\hat{b}_\lambda^\dagger \hat{d}_\sigma^\dagger | 0 \rangle$, in which one photon is already present while the trion is still excited and will emit the second one. It has to be stressed that these are not the single-photon states $\hat{b}_\lambda^\dagger \hat{a}_\sigma^\dagger | 0 \rangle$ entering Eq. (8). Two distinct routes populate this sector. In the first one the photon is created by the QD-cavity coupling and stays in the mode until the end of the pulse without leaving the cavity, so that the whole dynamics remains coherent; this is the resonant scattering of the laser photons. In the second one the first photon has actually escaped from the cavity at t_1 , and the remaining part of the pulse re-excites the QD, which then emits the second photon. Accordingly, the two-photon density matrix is a 4×4 matrix in the basis

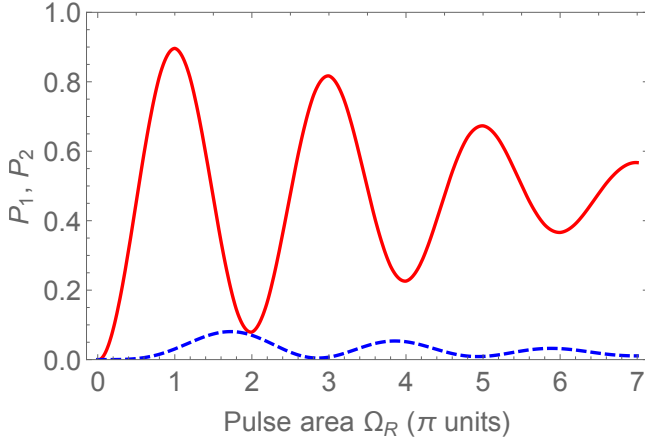


FIG. 2. Probabilities of the one-photon, P_1 (solid), and two-photon, P_2 (dashed), emission as functions of the pump pulse area.

$|\lambda\sigma\rangle$ and consists of two contributions, $\hat{\rho}_2 = \hat{\rho}_2^{\text{scat}} + \hat{\rho}_2^{\text{re-ex}}$, with

$$\begin{aligned} (\hat{\rho}_2^{\text{scat}})_{\lambda\sigma,\lambda'\sigma'} &= \langle 0 | \hat{d}_\sigma \hat{b}_\lambda \hat{\rho}(\tau) \hat{b}_{\lambda'}^\dagger \hat{d}_{\sigma'}^\dagger | 0 \rangle \\ (\hat{\rho}_2^{\text{re-ex}})_{\lambda\sigma,\lambda'\sigma'} &= \delta_{\lambda\lambda'} \Gamma \int_0^\tau dt_1 \langle 0 | \hat{d}_\sigma \hat{\rho}^{(\lambda)}(\tau | t_1) \hat{d}_{\sigma'}^\dagger | 0 \rangle \end{aligned} \quad (9)$$

The two routes differ by whether a real photon escape event has occurred during the pulse, and therefore do not interfere. The detector, on the other hand, registers only the polarizations of the two photons and not the instant at which the first one was emitted, so that the two contributions are summed as probabilities. This is the origin of the partial loss of the entanglement discussed below: the re-excitation term carries no coherence between the two circular polarizations of the first photon and thus dilutes the polarization correlations created by the coherent route.

The probabilities of the one- and two-photon emission are the traces of the corresponding density matrices,

$$P_1 = \text{Tr } \hat{\rho}_1, \quad P_2 = \text{Tr } \hat{\rho}_2 \quad (10)$$

All the results presented below are obtained by a numerical solution of Eq. (2) with the following set of parameters: the cavity mode width $\Gamma = 50 \mu\text{eV}$, the QD-cavity coupling $g = 25 \mu\text{eV}$, the detuning $\Delta = 50 \mu\text{eV}$, the pulse duration $\tau = 13 \text{ ps}$, the phonon coupling constant $\alpha = 0.2 \text{ ps}$, the transverse magnetic field $B_x = 5 \text{ T}$ and the lattice temperature $T = 1 \text{ K}$. The pulse area $\theta = \int \Omega_R(t) dt$ is varied by changing the pump power at a fixed pulse duration, and is measured below in units of π .

The emission probabilities are shown in Fig. 2. The one-photon probability P_1 exhibits damped Rabi oscillations with maxima at odd and minima at even multiples

of π , the damping being caused by the phonon-induced

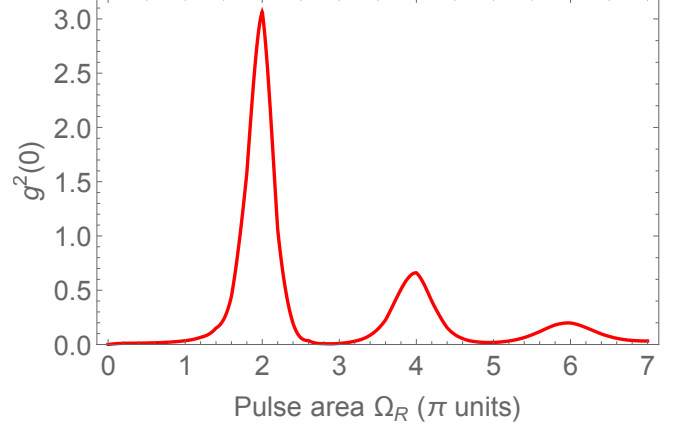


FIG. 3. Second-order correlation function at zero delay, $g^{(2)}(0)$, as a function of the pump pulse area.

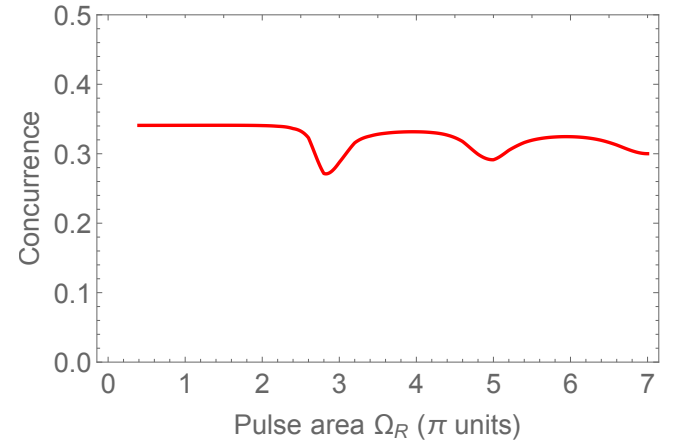


FIG. 4. Concurrence of the emitted two-photon polarization state as a function of the pump pulse area.

dephasing. The two-photon probability P_2 oscillates in antiphase and remains an order of magnitude smaller, reaching its maxima close to even pulse areas.

This antiphase behaviour is directly reflected in the second-order correlation function, Fig. 3. At odd pulse areas $g^{(2)}(0)$ nearly vanishes, so that the source emits single photons, whereas at even ones it displays pronounced bunching peaks, the largest reaching $g^{(2)}(0) \approx 3$ at $\theta = 2\pi$.

The polarization state of the emitted pair is characterized in Figs. 4 and 5. Both the concurrence and the fidelity to the Bell state $|\Phi^+\rangle$ are only weakly sensitive to the pump power, staying close to 0.34 and 0.62, respectively, over the whole range of pulse areas, with shallow minima near the odd ones. The fidelity exceeding $1/2$ confirms that the emitted pair is entangled for any excitation power.

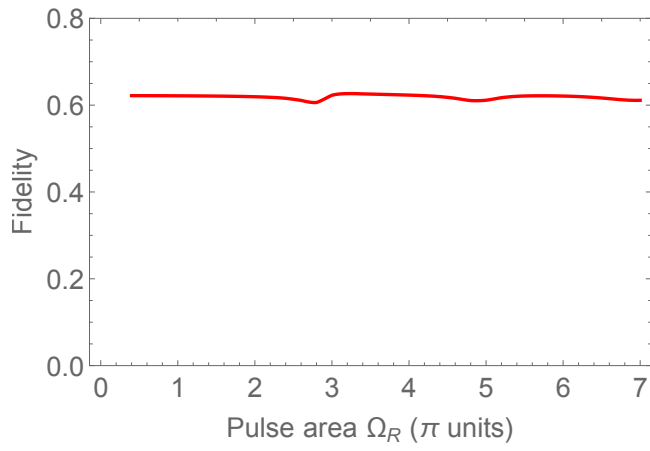


FIG. 5. Fidelity of the emitted two-photon polarization state to the Bell state $|\Phi^+\rangle$ as a function of the pump pulse area.